

BONUS 2

Flat Belly Pilates at Home

Pilates is a form of exercise with slow, controlled movements that mainly strengthens the **center of your body** — the belly and back area. With no equipment, no impact and without leaving home, it is perfect to go with your eating plan and speed up your results. All you need is a mat or a towel on the floor.

WHY THIS HELPS TO SLIM YOUR BELLY

- It strengthens the **deep belly muscle**, which works like a natural corset and holds your belly in.
- It improves your **posture** — and standing taller already makes your belly look visibly flatter.
- It shapes your **waist** by working the side muscles.
- It is **gentle on your joints**: ideal at any age.

AN IMPORTANT TRUTH

No exercise burns fat only on your belly — that does not exist. Fat comes off your whole body, and what drives that loss is your **food**. Pilates strengthens, shapes and improves your posture; together with the recipes in this book, it is the combination that really slims your belly. Consistency is everything.

How to use this: do it **3 to 4 times a week**, for 15 to 20 minutes. Wear comfortable clothes, train on an empty stomach or at least 1 hour after eating, and **keep breathing** (never hold your breath). Start with the easier variations given for each exercise and build up over time. If you feel a sharp pain, stop.

THE 12 EXERCISES

Do them in order, respecting the breathing and your own limit. Each exercise gives the focus, the number of reps, the step by step and, when there is one, an easier variation.

THE WEEKLY PLAN

Pick 3 to 4 days (for example **Monday, Wednesday and Friday**) and do the full sequence of the 12 exercises in the order they appear.

The order is deliberate: it starts with the **warm-up** (1 and 2), goes through the **belly** exercises (3 to 10), strengthens the **back** (11) and finishes with the **stretch** (12). Never skip the warm-up or the stretch.

1	Pilates Breathing (Switching On Your Abs)	5 breaths
2	Pelvic Tilt	2 sets of 10
3	The Hundred	1 set (count to 100)
4	Alternating Leg Lifts	2 sets of 12
5	Small Crunch (Trunk Lift)	3 sets of 12
6	Front Plank	3 times holding 20–40 s
7	Side Plank	2 times each side, 15–30 s
8	Glute Bridge	3 sets of 12
9	Roll Up	2 sets of 8
10	Bicycle Crunch	3 sets of 20 (10 each side)
11	Superman (Back Extension)	3 sets of 10
12	Final Stretch	Hold 30 s each

Pilates Breathing (Switching On Your Abs)

Before anything else, learn to switch your abs on from the inside — that is what makes Pilates work and your belly get firmer.



Beginner
LEVEL

5 breaths
SETS

2 min
TIME

FOCUS

Learning to squeeze the deep abdominal muscle — the base of every exercise.

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Lie on your back, with your knees bent and your feet flat on the floor, hip-width apart. Let your arms rest beside your body.
- 2 Put your hands on your belly. Breathe in through your nose, filling your belly like a balloon.
- 3 Breathe out slowly through your mouth and, at the same time, pull your belly button in toward your spine, as if you were zipping up a tight pair of pants.
- 4 Hold that squeeze for 3 seconds, feeling your belly firm, and relax.
- 5 Repeat 5 times, always breathing out and pulling your belly button in.

BREATHING

Breathe in through your nose filling your belly; breathe out through your mouth emptying it and squeezing your abs. Never hold your breath.

TIP

This 'pulling the belly button in' is the secret of Pilates. You will use this same squeeze in every other exercise — it is what works the deepest belly muscle, the one that holds everything in place and slims your waist.

Pelvic Tilt

A small, gentle movement that loosens your lower back and wakes up the lower part of your belly.

**Beginner**

LEVEL

2 sets of 10

SETS

3 min

TIME

FOCUS

Warming up the spine and switching on the lower belly.

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Stay lying on your back, knees bent and feet on the floor.
- 2 Breathe out and pull your belly button in, gently rolling your pelvis backward, so that your lower back presses fully into the floor.
- 3 Breathe in and come back slowly, leaving a small gap between your lower back and the floor.
- 4 Do the movement very slowly, as if you were drawing with your hips, without forcing it.
- 5 Repeat 10 times, rest and do another set of 10.

BREATHING

Breathe out as your lower back presses into the floor; breathe in as you come back. The movement follows your breathing.

TIP

It is a perfect warm-up for anyone with a sensitive lower back. The movement is short on purpose — what is in charge is the squeeze of your belly, not the strength of your back.

The Hundred

The classic that warms up your whole body and makes your abs burn — gently, but it burns.



Intermediate
LEVEL

1 set
(count to 100)
SETS

3 min
TIME

FOCUS

The most famous Pilates exercise for the whole abdomen.

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Lie on your back, bend your knees and lift your legs until they are bent at 90 degrees (shins parallel to the floor), as if you were sitting in an upside-down chair.
- 2 Breathe out, pull your belly button in and lift your head and shoulders slightly off the floor, looking at your belly. Stretch your arms straight beside your body, a hand's width above the floor.
- 3 Start pumping your arms up and down, with short, firm movements, as if you were slapping the water.
- 4 Count five pumps while you breathe in and five while you breathe out.
- 5 Keep going until you reach 100 pumps (or stop earlier if you get tired). Then lower your head and your legs and rest.

BREATHING

Breathe in for 5 pumps and breathe out for 5 pumps, without stopping the arm pumping.

TIP

Easier version: keep your feet on the floor and only lift your head and shoulders. Start with 30 or 50 pumps and build up to 100 over time.

Alternating Leg Lifts

A controlled movement that works exactly that lower belly area, the most stubborn one.

**Beginner**

LEVEL

2 sets of 12

SETS

3 min

TIME

FOCUS

The lower belly and control of the movement.

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Lie on your back, knees bent and feet flat on the floor. Keep your lower back pressed into the floor the whole time.
- 2 Breathe out, pull your belly button in and lift one foot off the floor, bringing your knee toward your belly, until your thigh is upright (90 degrees).
- 3 Breathe in and lower your foot slowly until it touches the floor again, with control.
- 4 Alternate: now lift the other leg the same way.
- 5 Do 12 reps with each leg, keeping your belly squeezed the whole time. Rest and repeat the set.

BREATHING

Breathe out as the leg goes up; breathe in as it comes down. Your abs stay firm the whole time.

TIP

What matters is not the speed, it is the control: the slower you lower the leg, the more your belly works. If you feel your lower back arching and lifting off the floor, raise the leg less.

Small Crunch (Trunk Lift)

The usual crunch, but done with Pilates control — it goes up a little and works a lot.



Beginner
LEVEL

3 sets of 12
SETS

4 min
TIME

FOCUS

The upper and middle part of the belly.

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Lie on your back, knees bent and feet on the floor. Cross your arms over your chest or rest your hands behind your head, without pulling on your neck.
- 2 Breathe out, pull your belly button in and curl your trunk upward, lifting your head and shoulders off the floor, as if you were bringing your ribs closer to your hips.
- 3 Only go up until the tips of your shoulder blades leave the floor (you do not need to sit up). Hold for 1 second at the top.
- 4 Breathe in and come down slowly, rolling your spine back to the floor, one vertebra at a time.
- 5 Repeat 12 times, rest and do 3 sets in total.

BREATHING

Breathe out as you go up (that is when your belly squeezes most); breathe in as you come down.

TIP

Do not pull your neck with your hands — your eyes look at your belly and your chin stays away from your chest, with room for an orange. What lifts your body is your abs, not your neck.

Front Plank

Still, but powerful: holding the plank strengthens your whole belly and your back at the same time.



Intermediate
LEVEL

3 times
holding
20–40 s
SETS

4 min
TIME

FOCUS

The whole abdomen, the lower back and posture — the most complete core exercise.

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Lie face down and rest your forearms on the floor, with your elbows under your shoulders. Your hands stay in front.
- 2 Stretch your legs back and rest your toes on the floor.
- 3 Breathe out, pull your belly button in and lift your body, keeping it straight like a board, from your heels to your head.
- 4 Keep your hips in line with your body — not lifted like a hill, and not dropped toward the floor. Look at the floor so you do not strain your neck.
- 5 Hold for 20 to 40 seconds, breathing normally. Come down, rest and repeat 3 times.

BREATHING

Keep breathing normally and slowly during the whole plank. Do not hold your breath.

TIP

Easier version: rest your knees on the floor (knee plank). Start by holding 15 seconds and build up little by little. If your lower back hurts, that is a sign your hips have dropped — lift them a little.

Side Plank

It is the exercise that shapes the side of your abs and defines your waist.



Intermediate
LEVEL

**2 times
each side,
15–30 s**
SETS

4 min
TIME

FOCUS

The side muscles of your belly (obliques) — it slims your waist.

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Lie on your side, with your body straight. Rest your bottom forearm on the floor, with your elbow under your shoulder.
- 2 Stack one leg on top of the other (one foot on top of the other).
- 3 Breathe out, pull your belly button in and lift your hips off the floor, keeping your body straight and supported only on your forearm and the side of your foot.
- 4 Stretch your top arm toward the ceiling or rest your hand on your waist. Hold for 15 to 30 seconds.
- 5 Come down with control, turn to the other side and repeat. Do it 2 times on each side.

BREATHING

Breathe normally and slowly while you hold the position.

TIP

Easier version: bend your knees and rest the lower part of your legs on the floor, lifting only your hips. Your waist is what works the most here — hold it firm.

Glute Bridge

It lifts your bottom, strengthens your abs from behind and also makes your posture look better.

**Beginner**

LEVEL

3 sets of 12

SETS

3 min

TIME

FOCUS

Glutes, the back of your thighs and your abs — and it relieves your lower back.

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Lie on your back, knees bent and feet flat on the floor, hip-width apart. Arms beside your body.
- 2 Breathe out, pull your belly button in and lift your hips off the floor, squeezing your glutes, until your body forms a straight line from your knees to your shoulders.
- 3 Hold for 2 seconds at the top, keeping your glutes and your belly firm.
- 4 Breathe in and lower your hips slowly, rolling your spine back to the floor, one vertebra at a time.
- 5 Repeat 12 times, do 3 sets.

BREATHING

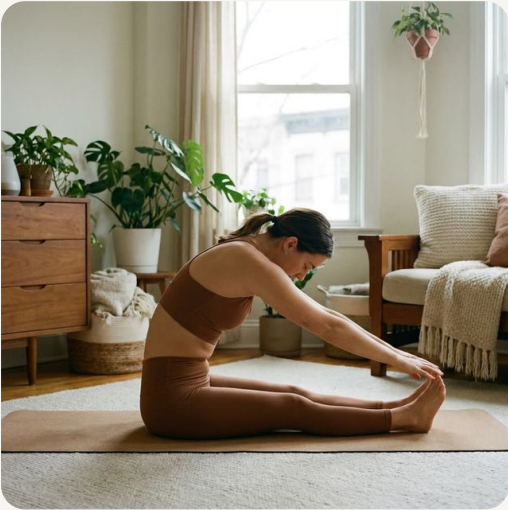
Breathe out as your hips go up; breathe in as they come down.

TIP

Go up by squeezing your glutes hard, not by pushing with your lower back. It is one of the few exercises that strengthens your belly and also relieves back pain — great for anyone who sits all day.

Roll Up

Sitting up and lying down by rolling your spine slowly — it looks simple, but your abs do all the work.



Intermediate
LEVEL

2 sets of 8
SETS

4 min
TIME

FOCUS

The whole abdomen and the flexibility of your spine.

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Lie on your back with your legs straight and your arms stretched back, above your head.
- 2 Breathe in and bring your arms forward, pointing at the ceiling.
- 3 Breathe out, pull your belly button in and start to sit up very slowly, rolling your spine: first your head, then your shoulders, then your back, until you are sitting and reaching your feet with your hands.
- 4 Breathe in at the top and, as you breathe out, come down the same way slowly, rolling your spine back to the floor, one vertebra at a time.
- 5 Repeat 8 times, with as much control as you can. Do 2 sets.

BREATHING

Breathe out while you go up and while you come down (that is when your belly works); breathe in during the pauses.

TIP

Easier version: bend your knees a little and, if you need to, give yourself a small push with your arms. What matters is going up and down slowly — the work is done by your belly, not your neck or your arms.

Bicycle Crunch

The pedaling movement that shapes the sides of your belly and lifts your heart rate a little.



Intermediate
LEVEL

**3 sets of
20 (10
each side)**
SETS

4 min
TIME

FOCUS

The obliques (sides of your belly) and the whole abdomen.

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Lie on your back, hands behind your head (without pulling on your neck). Lift your legs with your knees bent at 90 degrees.
- 2 Breathe out, pull your belly button in and lift your head and shoulders off the floor.
- 3 Rotate your trunk bringing your right elbow toward your left knee, while you stretch your right leg forward.
- 4 Come back to the center and do the other side: left elbow toward your right knee, stretching your left leg.
- 5 Keep alternating, as if you were pedaling a bicycle slowly. Do 20 in total (10 each side), 3 sets.

BREATHING

Breathe out at each rotation of your trunk; breathe in as you pass through the center.

TIP

Do it slowly and with control, not in a rush — the rotation of your trunk is what works the side of your belly. The further you stretch your leg away, the harder and the more effective it gets.

Superman (Back Extension)

After all those crunches, this one strengthens your back and improves your posture — which already makes your belly look flatter.



Beginner
LEVEL

3 sets of 10
SETS

3 min
TIME

FOCUS

Back and posture — it balances your body and makes your belly look flatter when you stand.

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Lie face down (belly down), with your arms stretched forward and your legs stretched back.
- 2 Breathe out, pull your belly button in slightly and lift your arms, your chest and your legs off the floor at the same time, a few inches, like Superman flying.
- 3 Hold for 2 seconds at the top, looking at the floor so you do not strain your neck.
- 4 Breathe in and come down slowly, relaxing.
- 5 Repeat 10 times, do 3 sets.

BREATHING

Breathe out as you lift; breathe in as you come down. A smooth movement, with no jerking.

TIP

You do not need to lift high — a few inches already work your back. Strengthening your back is essential: a strong back holds you upright, and good posture on its own already makes your belly look smaller.

Final Stretch

To finish, a nice stretch that relaxes the belly and the back you have just worked.

**All levels**

LEVEL

Hold 30 s**each**

SETS

3 min

TIME

FOCUS

Relaxing your spine and your abs after the workout.

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Get on all fours (hands and knees on the floor). Sit your bottom back onto your heels and stretch your arms forward, laying your trunk over your thighs (resting pose). Rest your forehead on the floor and breathe deeply for 30 seconds.
- 2 Lie back down on your back. Hug one knee at a time, pulling it toward your chest, and hold for 30 seconds on each side — that relaxes your lower back.
- 3 Finally, lying on your back with your arms open, let both knees fall slowly to one side and then to the other, gently twisting your spine, 30 seconds on each side.
- 4 Breathe deeply during the whole stretch, with no rush.
- 5 Get up slowly when you finish.

BREATHING

Breathe deeply and slowly, breathing out at each stretch and letting your body relax a little more.

TIP

Never skip the stretch: it relaxes the muscles that worked, prevents soreness the next day and improves your flexibility. It is the moment to feel your body and close the workout in peace.